

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 10



CHAPTER 10



FREEDOM

Later that same morning a boy brought Nat a note from Nathan Read, who had opened an apothecary shop in Salem.

Dear Nat

I have an apprentice in my shop who's interested in scientific things, too. If you'd like to come around on Sunday evening and talk with us, we'll enjoy having you.

Yours sincerely

NATHAN READ

During the rest of the week, Nat looked forward to Sunday evening. Mr. Read certainly would be an interesting man to know better. He was a jack of all trades who was a master of them, too.

Nat had heard stories of Mr. Read's days at Harvard — how when Nathan Read was just an undergraduate,

studying Hebrew, the professor in charge of the class got sick, and young Nathan had taken over the class and taught it.

He'd graduated with honors, had come to Salem and studied medicine; then he had decided to open his apothecary shop. Besides all his interest in medicine and drugs, he liked to work with machinery. He had applied to Congress for a patent on a steam engine he'd made to run a boat. He had also tried to get Congress to give him a patent on his idea for a steam wagon, too. But the Congressmen said that that idea was so crazy they wouldn't even consider it.

On Sunday evening, Mr. Read showed Nat his workbench, his tools, and his books. "You're welcome to use anything here," he said. He opened one heavy, leather-bound book. "This is one of the best things I have, but it's in French. Do you know French?"

"Not yet," Nat told him, "but I could learn it." And he told Mr. Read how he was studying Latin.

Mr. Read said, "A good idea! A grammar, a New Testament, and a dictionary, eh? I can let you have those in French."

Late the next afternoon, when Nat had a few minutes of free time in the chandlery, he opened the New Testament in French. He repeated the opening words of the Book of John to himself in English: In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

Then he read them in French: *Au commencement était la Parole, et la Parole était avec Dieu, et la Parole était Dieu.*

Frederic Jordy came in the shop. "I hear you want to study French, Mr. Bowditch? Maybe we could trade lessons. You could help me with my English, and I'll help you with French." He saw the New Testament. "You're beginning already, eh?"

"I've just looked at the first sentence," Nat said. "But I already see two words that are just the same as in English: *commencement* and —"

Mr. Jordy clutched his head. "No, no, that isn't the way to pronounce it!"

"Why not? It's the way it's spelled."

"But you must learn to pronounce it in French. Like this!" And Mr. Jordy gave the word its French sound.

Nat said, "I don't see how you get that out of it. French pronunciation must be crazy."

“Not at all!” Mr. Jordy insisted. “It is English pronunciation that is crazy. Take three words: rough, cough, and dough. Excepting for their first letter, they are all spelled alike. But how are they pronounced?”

Nat smiled. “All right; English pronunciation is crazy. But all I want of French is to be able to read it. Can you help me with that — and not bother about the pronunciation?”

"Never! I couldn't stand hearing you mangle it!"

Nat shrugged. "All right; I'll learn to pronounce it, too."

With Latin and *Principia*, with French and the Kirwan books, and his evenings with Mr. Read, Nat filled every minute when he wasn't working at the chandlery, eating, or sleeping.

December passed; a new year began. A nor'easter howled in from the Atlantic and smothered Salem in snowdrifts. For three days Nat sat in the chandlery and studied almost undisturbed.

The fourth morning Elizabeth Boardman came.

Nat smiled at her. "My first customer today. What can I do for you?"

"When Father gets back from the West Indies, I want to surprise him."

Nat smiled. "That shouldn't be hard to do. You can surprise anyone without half trying."

Elizabeth studied him gravely. "Sometimes I'm not sure what you're talking about."

"We're even," Nat told her. "How do you want to surprise your father?"

"With a present. He always brings me something." Elizabeth's eyes danced. "This time I want to give him a present. Something he can use."

"Hmmm. How much can you pay for it?"

"Oh, that doesn't matter. Mother said I could get anything I wanted to."

Nat studied. "Parallel rulers might be nice."

"Do you suppose Father has them already?"

Nat exploded. "Of course! What sort of sailing master do you think he is?" Then he apologized quickly. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to bark at you."

"I know. I'm just like a chair you stumble over in the dark," Elizabeth said. "It isn't the chair's fault, but you kick it anyhow."

Nat blinked. "What are you talking about?"

"Your brain. It's too fast. So you stumble on other people's dumbness. And — you want to kick something."

Nat felt his face get hot. "But I shouldn't."

Elizabeth agreed. "No, you shouldn't, because even if people are dumb, they aren't chairs, are they? They do have feelings."

"Lizza was right," Nat said. "You do have eyes in the back of your heart. Come on over here, and I'll show you how your father uses parallel rulers." He smiled. "And you may ask all the questions you want to, and I promise not to bark."

In the weeks that followed, he explained a lot of things to Elizabeth; sextants and logs, spyglasses and dividers. It was March before she finally decided on the present — binoculars.

When she had paid for them she said, "I'm going to watch for his ship tomorrow — up on the captain's walk on the roof of our house."

Nat stared. "Tomorrow? Why are you so sure he'll come tomorrow?"

Elizabeth flushed, fingering the screw on the binoculars. "I didn't mean just tomorrow; I mean — I'm going to watch for him every morning — until he comes." And she hurried out.

Smiling, Nat watched her go. That hadn't been what she meant, at all. She was going to watch for her father's ship tomorrow morning.

And I wouldn't be surprised, Nat told himself, if Captain Boardman's ship did arrive tomorrow.

The next morning Dr. Bentley stopped at the chandlery with news. Dr. Bentley often brought the first news of a returning ship. Almost every morning he took a walk out on the Neck and stared out over the water.

Captain George Crowninshield had built a lookout there for him on a high point — a solid granite base, with steps leading up to a seat. There was a flagstaff there, so that Dr. Bentley could run up signals.

"There's bad news, Nat. A ship's coming in with its flag at half-mast. Something's happened to the captain."

Nat's tongue felt thick in his mouth. "What ship?"

Dr. Bentley shook his head. "I'm not sure. I ran my signal to half-mast, and then hurried back. I want to be at the wharf when the ship anchors."

I know who it is, Nat thought. He felt a chill prickle his scalp and run down his spine.

It was Sam who brought the final news. Captain Boardman had died in the West Indies.

Two other ships anchored in Salem Harbor that day. Men crowded the chandlery with talk and with orders. It was late that night before Nat locked the door.

He hadn't thought where he was going until he found himself crossing the Commons toward Captain Boardman's big white house. As he neared the house, he looked up toward the captain's walk and saw Elizabeth.

When he reached the house, old Minna, Mrs. Boardman's maid, opened the door.

Nat said, "I don't want to disturb Mrs. Boardman. I just wanted to speak to Elizabeth. I believe she's on the captain's walk."

Old Minna dabbed at her eyes with her apron. "Oh, Mr. Nat, if only you will! The child is bound and determined to be up there. I can't do a thing with her. I don't dare tell her mother. I swore Elizabeth was in bed, fast asleep."

Nat climbed to the captain's walk. The trap door creaked when he opened it.

Elizabeth whirled to face him. "I won't come down! I . . . Oh, it's you, Nat. I'm glad." She clutched the binoculars. "Mother says I may keep them."

"That's good," Nat said. "But we don't need them for what we're going to see now. I'm going to show you how to tell time by the Big Dipper and the North Star. Can you find the Dipper?"

Elizabeth studied the stars a moment. "Is that it — upside down?"

"You've found it, all right. Now, look at the stars on the side of the Dipper across from the handle. And imagine a line running through them and slanting down."

"It goes through another star."

Nat said, "That's the North Star. If you think of the North Star as the middle of your clock face, and the line from it through those other stars as the hour hand, you can tell time."

"It says about one o'clock. Is that right?"

"No, this clock runs backwards."

"Is it eleven o'clock?"

"No, there's one other difference. It takes twenty-four hours for the Big Dipper to swing around the North Star. So every hour space on the clock face stands for two hours."

Elizabeth sighed. "There goes your brain again." She studied. "Ten o'clock?"

"You're doing fine." Nat went on talking.

Finally Elizabeth said, "I'm sleepy, Nat."

They tiptoed down from the captain's walk. Old Minna was waiting for them. She went to the door with Nat.

"Bless you, Mr. Nat. I don't know what you said to her, but there's peace in her eyes now."

"We looked at the stars," Nat told her. "Sometimes, if you look at the stars long enough, they sort of shrink your troubles down to size."

Minna shook her gray head. "I haven't a notion what you're talking about, but I'm sure it's wonderful. You know, you're real humanlike — in spite of your brains."

Nat bit back a smile. "Thank you, Minna."

"You're indentured, aren't you, Mr. Nat?"

"Yes, Minna."

"Have you thought about what you'll do when you're free?"

Nat smiled. "First thing, I'll hire a fife and drum and have a one-man parade down Derby Street!"

A puzzled frown wrinkled Minna's forehead. "I've never seen a body do that. My brother John was indentured. I remember what he said when he was free. He said he felt real lost-like at first."

Sometimes, in the two years that followed, Nat thought of Minna's words. What would he do when he was free? Where would he find a place in the world? He thought about it especially whenever Hab or William or David was home between voyages. Each of them talked of "his ship." Each had found his place in the world.

Nat wondered again, when the last of his brothers went to sea. Sammy was sixteen when he swaggered into the chandlery one day and grinned down at Nat. "Just came

to say good-bye for a while. My ship's bound for Jamaica."

Nat smiled and shook hands and watched Sammy swagger out of the shop to board his ship. His ship. Sammy had found his place, too. Nat shrugged and turned back to his bookkeeping. Even while he was still thinking of Sammy, his glance flicked down a column of figures and his fingers jotted the answer. He realized his mind was wandering. He jerked his thoughts back in line, and added the figures again. He'd been right the first time. For almost nine years now, he'd been right about figures. What would he do with the next nine years? Go on adding columns and columns of figures?

The week before he was twenty-one Nat awakened with a feeling of something hanging over him. He sat up slowly and looked about his garret room. How many times, his first year in this room, had he fought back tears? He had been so alone. No one to say good night to, no one to sit and talk to — no one. He had had nothing but the books he studied and the things he copied into his notebooks.

For nine years this room had been his home. In a week, it would all be over. He'd be free. He could come and go as he pleased.

"I'll be free," he muttered, "and I know now what Minna's brother meant. I'm beginning to feel lost-like, too."

As he got out of bed a piece of white paper under the door caught his glance. He picked it up and read:

Dear Nat

In case you've forgotten, you have just another week until your twenty-first birthday. We hope you'll want to stay on in this room. We're sure it would feel empty without you. So, as long as you care to stay, and whatever you're doing, think of this room as your home. Will you? We . . .

There was more, but the words blurred.